central leadership. Data from: https://www.bjp.org/en/nationalofficebearers; https://cpim.org/leadership; https://www.communistparty.in/blank-1; https://www.ncp.org.in/about/; https://www.inc.in/aicc-office-bearers; https://www.bspindia.org/our-leadership/. Accurate as of 21 October 2020.

This is in sharp contrast to the Congress. It is led by a woman president, Sonia Gandhi. However, including her and her daughter Priyanka Gandhi—both dynastic leaders—the proportion of women in the Congress's central leadership is half that of the BJP. The primary difference between the two parties on this issue is that the BJP embraced a wider social coalition of women as part of a methodical growth plan. The Congress did not. Similarly, in the Left, in 2020, the CPI(M)'s all-powerful Politburo had only two women members: Brinda Karat and Subhashini Ali, both from an older generation of leadership. In Maharashtra's NCP too, while Supriya Sule, Sharad Pawar's daughter, is the anointed heir, the overall representation of women in leadership positions is way lower than in the BJP. The Trinamool Congress, led by Mamata Banerjee, is a different case. Banerjee is all-powerful in her party, and while she brought in more women leaders at the state-party level in 2020, its impact was only relevant in Bengal. Tellingly, even her council of ministers, in which she holds the lion's share of portfolios, had only 6 per cent women leaders in October 2020, if you count individuals. Mayawati's iron hold over the BSP similarly failed to build a recognisable second-line of women leadership.

These comparisons show that the BJP systematically broad-based its leadership in terms of gender representation after 2014 in a way that other parties did not. On every measurable quantitative yardstick of gender representation—the number of women who voted for it, the number of women who were given Lok Sabha tickets, the number of women who were made ministers and the number of women appointed as national office-bearers—the new BJP did better than its national political rivals.

The BJP's UP Model of Reservation for Women at the Booth and District Levels: Veerangana Sammelans and Gender-based Mobilisation